

crime SALMAN KHAN

■ By Kaveree Bamzai and Rohit Parihar

When Salman Khan was growing up as a teenager in Mumbai's Bandra, he would often drive autorickshaws at night to earn pocket money. He does that even now, sometimes, but only for fun, racing up and down Bandstand, the strip of road that serenades the Arabian Sea, with friends. Here is the man who has delivered this year's biggest hit, *Partner*, who makes Rs 5 crore for every film, and thinks nothing of signing a cheque for the lifelong education of three children of a beggar he met at a railway station in Ooty. At 42, despite the hard knocks he has administered to himself, having been in prison on four different occasions in two different cities, Salman remains the St Stanislaus schoolboy, still living a floor below his parents' house, in a modest two-bedroom apartment, firmly tied to the umbilical cord.

As his anxious family camps in Jodhpur's Taj Hari Mehal hotel, joined by friends, filmmaker David Dhawan, Boney Kapoor and Sajid Nadiadwala, the cord is strained to the limit. Salim Khan, one charismatic half of the extraordinary scriptwriter duo that ruled the '70s, is emotional as he narrates his 20-meeting in jail with his son. "I went and sat quietly with him. Both of us had tears in our eyes and both of us didn't want the other to see. *"Kya use image ki saza mil rahi hai ya gunah ki* (is he being punished for his image or his crime?)" he says. As his son, currently prisoner No. 343 in Jodhpur's high security Central Jail, is sentenced to a five-year simple imprisonment by Sessions Court Judge Kamal Raj Singhvi for poaching, pending appeal before the Rajasthan High Court, it is a question which must be haunting him.

There's a lot else. Salman faces three cases under the 1972 Wildlife Act and one under the Arms Act 1959, for an alleged hunting spree during the making of Sooraj Barjatya's *Hum Saath Saath Hain* in 1998. He was sentenced to a year-long imprisonment in the first case, in which an appeal is still pending. Fellow accused Satish Shah was, however, acquitted. This five-year term is in a second case. There is a third case where Saif Ali Khan, Sonali Bendre, Neelam and Tabu are said to have accompanied him and a fourth

case under the Arms Act, both still pending at the trial stage. His is not the first conviction under the Wildlife Act in Rajasthan—one Basti Ram was sent to prison for two years—but it is certainly the best known.

Unlike his troubled compatriot and fellow Bandra cowboy, Sanjay Dutt, out on bail for a month after being sentenced to six years under the Arms Act, Salman has never played the media martyr. As his father puts it: "His biggest mistake was that he didn't know how powerful the media has become. There has been nothing but mutual dislike between them. Whether it was his height, his hair, his family or his relationships, they have always portrayed him as a superbrat." Indeed. The Salman the world knows has been prematurely buried—he has shot dead three chinkaras and two blackbucks, his Toyota Landcruiser has run down a sleeping pavement dweller, and he has talked sweetly to underworld dons and abusively to his girlfriends. This is the image of Salman as Bollywood's bad boy, less likely to be spotted at his neighbourhood Barista and more likely to be seen in a strobe-lit den with slinky starlets. This is Salman, partly as media construct, and partly as the out-

THE BATTLE BEGINS:
Salman Khan



THE BUCK STOP

come of his own self-indulgent behaviour, sometimes under the influence of too many Bacardis and sometimes just high on the essence of fame. This is not the fraternal bhai that his buddies talk about in a non-stop sugar rush but the dangerous bhai of the criminal kind.

Last week, the two Salmans were again up for wall to wall live television scrutiny. There was Salman on the balcony of his Galaxy Apartment flat (now surely the second most famous address in Mumbai after Jalsa and Prateeksha) compelled to show himself after being declared an absconder by the 24-hour news. But there was also the Salman who despite the verdict ticking like a time bomb completed the first schedule of friend Boney Kapoor's *Wanted: Dead and Alive*. He had been wanting to be directed by Prabhudeva,

had lost weight for the role and was gung-ho about the action man with attitude. That attitude was in evidence as he walked to the car that would take him to Mumbai airport on the way to Jodhpur—here was Bollywood's tough Salmanbhai, rippling muscles threatened to leap out of his demure white T-shirt, eyes unseeing behind fashionable dark glasses, ready to explode. This was no crouching tiger, Dutt aka Sanjubaba, tormented by 14 years of a prolonged case, racked by the deaths of his mother, first wife and father, and wrung out by the guilt of his mistake. Both stars are, says filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt, playing roles assigned to them by the media. For one man, Bollywood weeps, for another, there is a clear sympathy deficit. In one man, TV audiences see the spirit of Munnabhai, in another